



◀ Queen of pinups

Iconic images of model Bettie Page made her a sex symbol in the 1950s and helped usher in the sexual revolution of the 1960s. Her style of curves, high heels, and raven bangs still influences ideas about sexual allure today.

Many modern beauty trends can be traced to the past. Beauty pageants have their origins in competitions held in ancient Troy, where a panel of artists, philosophers, poets, and warriors judged the most beautiful woman of the day. The current preoccupation with hair removal is also ages old, with women using such deadly methods as arsenic in medieval times. Eyelash extensions were first explored in the late 1800s and involved stitching a hair into the eyelid with an ordinary needle.

It was only in the 1920s, when women began to compete with men in the workplace, that a thin, boyish figure became fashionable. Undergarments helped to flatten the chest, and diet and exercise regimes became popular to achieve a lean look. In response to criticism in the 1990s that the fashion and beauty industries were promoting unrealistic body types, these businesses now promote more fluid beauty ideals. Dominant images float between two desirable aesthetics: one that promotes big busts and exaggerated buttocks; the other the leaner, more athletic lines of the catwalk model. At the same time, the cosmetic industry has created products for a wider variety of skin tones, as well as an array of injectable substances capable of transforming the face and body.



PROFILES

BEAUTY QUEENS

Queen Elizabeth I (1533-1603) cultivated her image as England's "Virgin Queen" by wearing low-cut necklines, a style considered only appropriate for virginal women. As she grew older, she wore red wigs to conceal her graying hair, and applied a dangerous lead whitening paste to her skin to mask signs of aging. Women at court copied her, even mimicking her rotten teeth by blackening their own.

Florence Nightingale Graham (1878-1966) built a cosmetics empire under the name Elizabeth Arden. She traveled from rural Canada to the US and opened her first Red Door Salon on New York's Fifth Avenue in 1910. Arden created products that emphasized natural beauty, such as her Eight Hour Cream. Her mantra was: "To be beautiful and natural is the birthright of every woman."

ORLAN (b.1947) is a French artist who explores cultural perceptions of women's bodies by undergoing extreme cosmetic procedures and recording them as performance art. Starting in 1990, ORLAN embarked on a series of plastic surgeries to transform her features into those of iconic beauties in art, including the forehead of Leonardo da Vinci's *Mona Lisa* and the chin of Sandro Botticelli's *Venus*.

Zara Mohamed Abdulmajid (b.1955), known professionally as Iman, is a Somali model famed for being one of the first women of color to succeed in high fashion. Discovered in 1975, she went on to become a favorite of designer Yves Saint Laurent, and married British rock star David Bowie in 1992. In 1994 she started a successful cosmetics range for women with darker skin.

Naomi Wolf (b.1962) is a US feminist, journalist, and author. In her landmark book published in 1991, *The Beauty Myth*, she argued that unrealistic social standards of physical beauty are harmful to women and hinder their effectiveness in society. Wolf later became a prominent spokeswoman for third-wave feminism.

Ashley Graham (b.1987) is a trailblazing US fashion model and lingerie designer who became the first plus-size model to be listed among the top-earning models by *Forbes Magazine* in 2017. Graham, who shot to fame after appearing on the cover of a *Sports Illustrated* swimsuit issue, campaigns for the "normalization" of larger women, who, as she points out, are the norm in the US.